"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 32

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

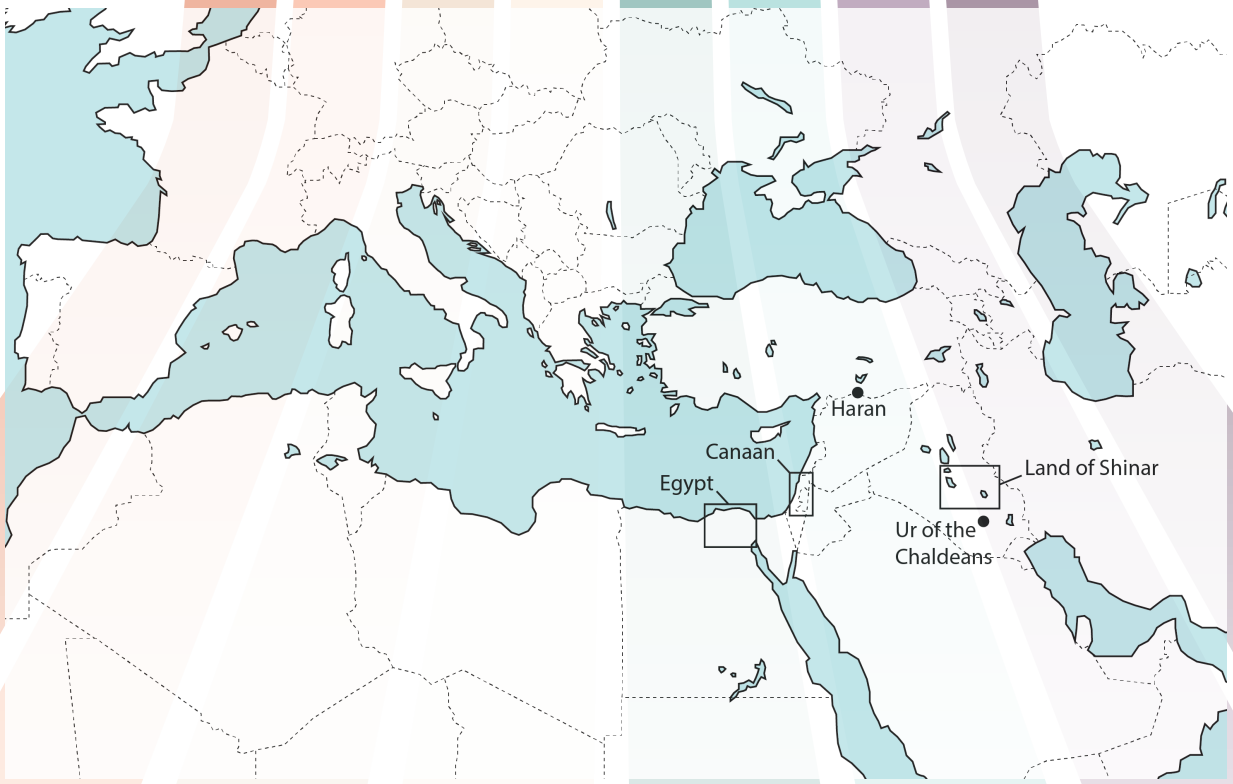
- The exact date of Jacob's return to Canaan is not known, but using information throughout Genesis, it seems likely it occurred between 1745-1725 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau.
- Esau – Jacob's brother who he hadn't seen in 20 years. Esau was planning to kill Jacob the last time they were in each other's presence (27:41).
- Wrestling Man – Jacob wrestled a mysterious man near the ford of Jabbok.

Where:

- Jacob lived in Haran for 20 years but returned to Canaan in Genesis 31-33.
- Jacob wrestled with the mysterious man in Peniel (near the ford of Jabbok).



Outline:

- JACOB PREPARES TO MEET ESAU AFTER 20 YEARS APART (32:1-21):
    + After making a treaty of peace with Laban, Jacob prepared to reunite with his brother Esau.
    + Jacob left Canaan on bad terms with his brother after stealing his blessing (27:1-29).
    + He feared how Esau might respond when he saw him again.
    + Jacob sent messengers to Esau and Esau came to meet him with 400 men.
    + Jacob feared Esau might attack him, so he split his family into two groups, thinking if one were attacked, the other would survive.
    + A prayer to the Lord was offered by Jacob, thanking God for His past care of him, and asking the Lord to protect him as he met his brother.
    + Presents were sent ahead of Jacob to be given to Esau as he approached: 200 female goats, 20 male goats, 200 ewes, 20 rams, 30 milking camels and their calves, 40 cows, 10 bulls, 20 female donkeys, and 10 male donkeys.
    + Jacob told his servants to refer him as the "servant of Esau" when they delivered the gift.
- JACOB WRESTLES WITH GOD (32:22-32):
    + Jacob sent his wives and children ahead of him while he remained alone.
    + That night, a man wrestled with Jacob until the break of day.
    + While wrestling, the man touched Jacob's hip socket and put it out of joint.
    + Jacob thought he was winning the wrestling match, and he demanded the other man bless him if he wanted to be let go.
    + The man blessed him by changing his name from Jacob to Israel because he had "striven with God and with men" and had prevailed (32:28).
    + Jacob asked the man his name, and the stranger replied, "Why is it that you ask my name?"
    + Jacob named the place Peniel, saying, "For I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered."
    + Due to his hip being put out of joint, Jacob was left with a limp.

Application:

- Don't get caught up speculating and miss the most important information God is sharing with us.
- If you are like me, you probably have a lot of questions about this mysterious wrestling match between God and Jacob.
- Why did God want to wrestle? Why was Jacob winning? Why did the wrestling match need to end when the sun rose?
- All of these are fair questions and worth thinking about, but don't miss the key details that are easily understood from this text.
- God blessed Jacob by changing his name to Israel. This is hugely important because it explains how Jacob's descendance, who we will read about through the rest of the Old Testament, became known as the Israelites.
- It's not wrong to ponder the mysteries of the Bible, but don't spend all your time thinking about the details we aren't given to the neglect of the details we are given.